490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 24 OF 26

Paul's Journeys and Letters

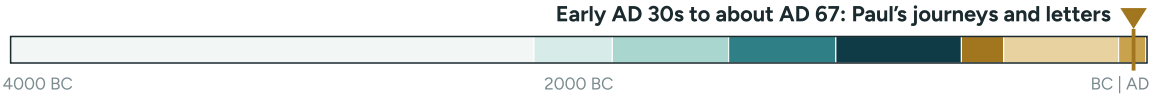
Acts 9; 13–28; Romans



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 24



Introduction: The Man Nobody Expected

If you had been a Christian in Jerusalem a few years after the cross, the last man on earth you would have expected to become a Christian was Saul of Tarsus. He was a brilliant young Pharisee, one of the strictest keepers of the Jewish law, "educated at the feet of Gamaliel according to the strict manner of the law of our fathers" (Acts 22:3). He had watched Stephen die and approved (Acts 7:58; 8:1). Then he went from house to house dragging believers off to prison (Acts 8:3). The church was afraid of him, and they had reason to be.

Yet this man became the apostle Paul. He traveled something like ten thousand miles on foot and by sea, planted churches across what is now Turkey and Greece, and wrote thirteen of the twenty-seven books of the New Testament. More than anyone besides Jesus himself, he explained what the cross means and how a sinner can be right with God.

This lesson follows Paul from the Damascus road to a rented house in Rome, from the early AD 30s to about AD 62, covering Acts 9 and 13–28, and then to his death a few years later. Then it opens his greatest letter, Romans, to hear the gospel he preached. Lesson 25 turns to the letters of Peter, James, John, and Hebrews.

The Word: Justified

> **Romans 5:1** *"Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ."*

δικαιόω *(dikaioō, "to justify")*

to declare righteous; a courtroom word

The verdict

Rom. 8:33

"It is God who justifies." The Judge himself pronounces us in the right.

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The ground

Rom. 3:24

"Justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

Payoff: To justify someone is to declare him righteous in court. It does not mean to make him a better person; that is a different work, which God also does. Justification is a verdict. God pardons all our sins and accepts us as righteous in his sight, only for the righteousness of Christ counted to us and received by faith alone (WSC 33). Abraham "believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness" (Rom. 4:3). The same is true for everyone who trusts Christ.

Part One: The Persecutor Becomes the Apostle

Saul was on his way to Damascus with letters authorizing him to arrest Christians when a light from heaven flashed around him and he fell to the ground. Jesus spoke: "I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting." Blinded, Saul was led by the hand into the city. Three days later a frightened believer named Ananias came and laid hands on him. Something like scales fell from his eyes, and he was baptized (Acts 9:3–18).

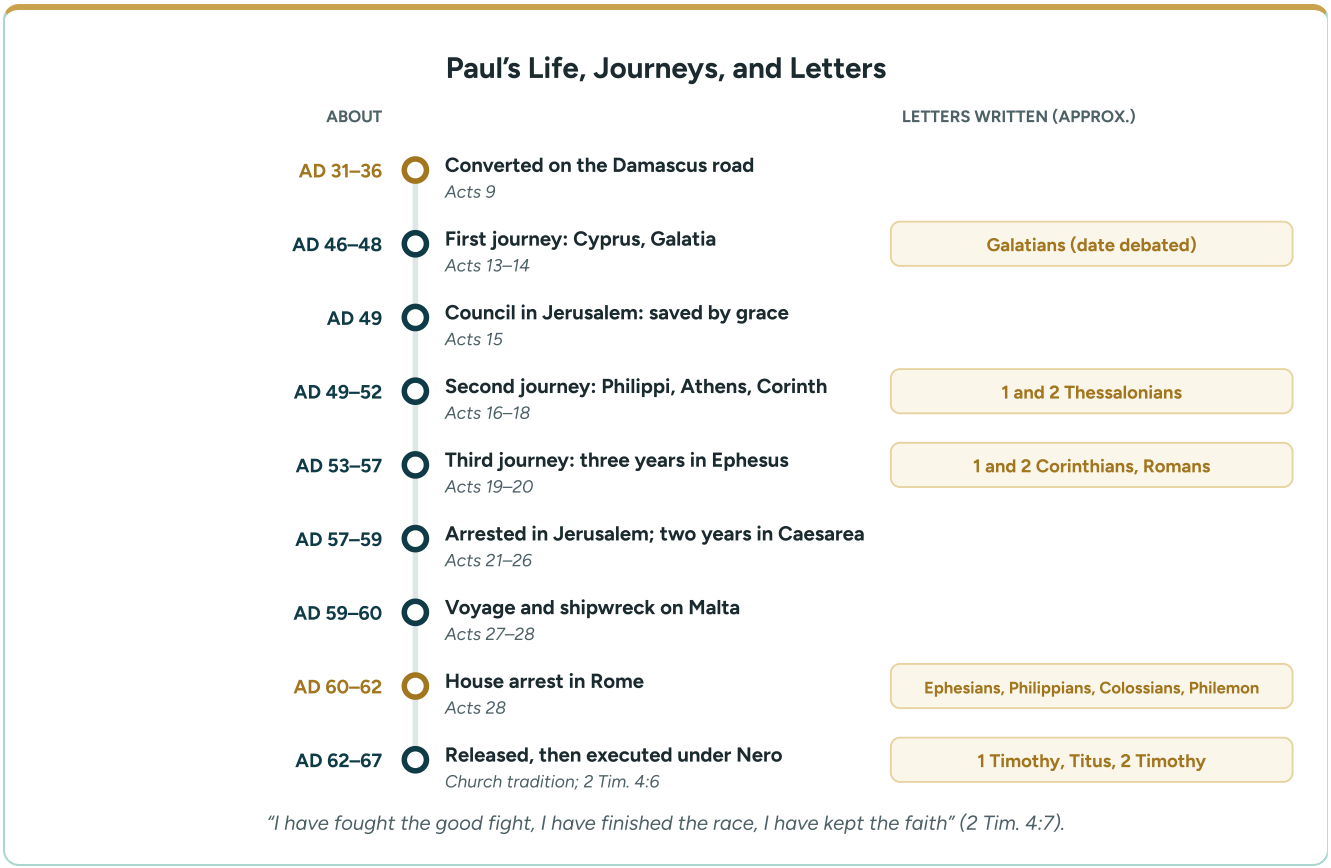
The Lord had told Ananias why: "he is a chosen instrument of mine to carry my name before the Gentiles and kings and the children of Israel" (9:15). Years later Paul remembered Jesus' words to him that day: he was sent "to open their eyes, so that they may turn from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God, that they may receive forgiveness of sins" (26:18).

The change was immediate. "And immediately he proclaimed Jesus in the synagogues, saying, 'He is the Son of God'" (9:20). Paul never got over the grace of it. "I am the least of the apostles," he wrote, "unworthy to be called an apostle, because I persecuted the church of God. But by the grace of God I am what I am" (1 Cor. 15:9–10). If God could save Saul, there is no one too far gone for him.

Part Two: The Journeys

About AD 46, the church in Antioch was worshiping and fasting when "the Holy Spirit said, 'Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them'" (13:2). That began the first of three great missionary journeys. Along the way Luke starts using his Roman name: "Saul, who was also called Paul" (13:9). He did not get a new name at his conversion. Like many Jews of his day, he had carried both names all along. Paul's pattern was simple. He went to a city, preached first in the Jewish synagogue, and

then turned to the Gentiles (13:46). He told them that "through this man forgiveness of sins is proclaimed to you" (13:38). Some believed, others stirred up trouble, and at Lystra he was stoned and left for dead (14:19). He got up and went back into the city (14:20).



As Gentiles came to faith, a hard question arose: did they have to become Jews, be circumcised and keep the law of Moses, to be saved? About AD 49 the apostles and elders met in Jerusalem to decide. Peter said it plainly: "we believe that we will be saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus, just as they will" (15:11). Salvation is by grace, for Jew and Gentile alike.

On his second journey Paul crossed into Europe. In Philippi a businesswoman named Lydia listened, and "The Lord opened her heart to pay attention to what was said by Paul" (16:14). Then Paul and his new partner Silas were beaten and thrown in prison. At midnight they were "praying and singing hymns to God" when an earthquake shook the doors open. The jailer, about to kill himself, cried out, "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?" They answered, "Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household." That night he and all his family were baptized (16:25–33).



"The God who made the world and everything in it, being Lord of heaven and earth, does not live in temples made by man" (Acts 17:24).

In Athens, still the proud university city of the Greek world, Paul stood before the philosophers at the Areopagus, the city's ancient council, which met on a rocky hill near the Acropolis and wanted to hear his "new teaching" (17:19). He started where they were, with an altar "To the unknown god," and told them who that God is: the Creator who "gives to all mankind life and breath and everything." Then he called them to turn: "now he commands all people everywhere to repent, because he has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed; and of this he has given assurance to all by raising him from the dead" (17:23, 25, 30–31). Some mocked. A few believed.

He spent a year and a half in Corinth (18:11) and about three years in Ephesus (20:31). The cost was enormous. He listed it once: beaten with rods three times, "Once I was stoned. Three times I was shipwrecked," in danger from robbers and rivers, in hunger and cold, and on top of it all, "the daily pressure on me of my anxiety for all the churches" (2 Cor. 11:25–28). His answer to all of it: "I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God" (Acts 20:24).

Part Three: In Chains to Rome

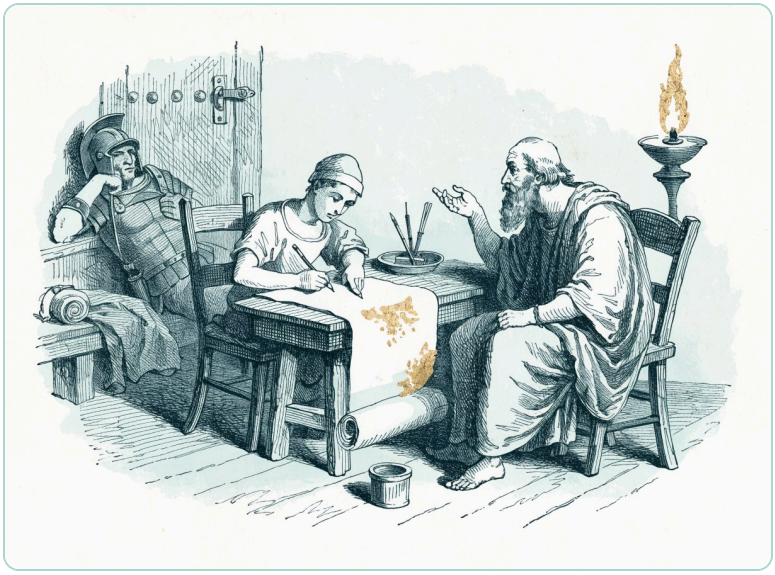
About AD 57 Paul returned to Jerusalem, where a mob seized him in the temple. He was arrested, held for two years in Caesarea, and finally, as a Roman citizen, he appealed to the emperor (25:11). On the way to Rome his ship was caught in a storm for two weeks and wrecked on the island of Malta, but every one of the 276 people on board reached shore alive, just as God had promised Paul (27:24, 37, 44).

Acts ends with Paul under house arrest in Rome, the capital of the world, chained to a guard. "He lived there two whole years at his own expense, and welcomed all who came to him, proclaiming the kingdom of God and teaching about the Lord Jesus Christ with all boldness and without hindrance" (28:30–31). In Greek the very last word of Acts is *akōlytōs*, "unhindered," which the ESV renders "without hindrance."

Paul was in chains, but as he later wrote, “the word of God is not bound!” (2 Tim. 2:9). Jesus had told his followers they would be his witnesses “to the end of the earth” (Acts 1:8). Now the message had reached the heart of the empire.

Church tradition tells us Paul was later released for a time, then arrested again and beheaded in Rome under Nero, around AD 64 to 67. His last letter, written as he waited for death, says, “I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith. Henceforth there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness” (2 Tim. 4:7–8).

Part Four: The Gospel in a Letter



Paul often dictated his letters to a scribe and signed them with his own hand. Some he wrote in chains (Rom. 16:22; Col. 4:18).

Paul could not stay in every church he planted, so he wrote to them. His letters answered their questions, corrected their mistakes, and above all explained the gospel. He wrote Romans about AD 57 to a church he had never visited, laying out the good news from beginning to end. Many Christians have found it the clearest explanation of the gospel ever written. Here is its argument in brief.

The Gospel According to Romans

Romans 1–3	**The bad news** All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God	*Rom. 3:23*
Romans 3–5	**Justified by faith** Declared righteous as a gift, through Christ's blood	*Rom. 3:24–25; 5:1*
Romans 6–8	**New life in the Spirit** United to Christ, no condemnation, never separated	*Rom. 6:4; 8:1, 39*
Romans 9–11	**God keeps his word** His plan for Israel and the nations will not fail	*Rom. 11:33–36*
Romans 12–16	**A living sacrifice** Grace changes how we live together	*Rom. 12:1–2*

"The righteous shall live by faith" (Rom. 1:17).

The bad news. Paul begins with everyone's problem. "None is righteous, no, not one; no one understands; no one seeks for God" (Rom. 3:10–11). Religious people and irreligious people alike are guilty before God: "for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God" (3:23).

The good news. Then the turn: we "are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith" (3:24–25). A propitiation is a sacrifice that turns away God's just anger against sin. At the cross Jesus bore that anger in our place. God did this "so that he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus" (3:26). Justification is a gift, received by faith, not earned by works. "For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast" (Eph. 2:8–9).

CORE DOCTRINE 24 OF 26 · FAITH ALONE

Justification by Faith Alone

God declares guilty sinners righteous in his sight. He pardons all their sins and counts Christ's perfect righteousness as theirs. He does this only because of what Christ has done, never because of what they have done, and they receive it by faith alone. Good works follow as the fruit of being justified. They are never the reason for it.

KEY VERSES

Romans 3:23–26; 4:5; 5:1; Galatians 2:16; Ephesians 2:8–9

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

"Justification is an act of God's free grace, wherein he pardoneth all our sins, and accepteth us as righteous in his sight, only for the righteousness of Christ imputed to us, and received by faith alone." (Westminster Shorter Catechism 33)

WHY IT MATTERS

Your standing with God does not rise and fall with your performance. If you trust Christ, his record is counted as yours, and nothing can change that verdict.

The love behind it. "But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (Rom. 5:8). God did not wait for us to clean ourselves up.

A new life. Does grace mean we can keep on sinning? "By no means! How can we who died to sin still live in it?" (6:1–2). Faith unites us to Christ, and in him God gives two gifts that always come together. He declares us righteous once for all, and he gives us his Spirit, who begins the lifelong work of making us holy. The first is a verdict and the second is a growth. They are different, but no one ever has one without the other. Good works are the fruit of salvation, never its root.

An unbreakable hope. Romans 8 begins, "There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (8:1), and ends with nothing in all creation "able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord" (8:39). In between is a chain God himself holds together: "those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified" (8:30). To be predestined means God set his love on his people before the world began. Paul writes this to comfort people who trust Christ: their salvation rests on God's own purpose, so it cannot fail. No one has to solve the mystery of God's choice before coming to him. Jesus said, "whoever comes to me I will never cast out" (John 6:37). God finishes what he starts.

A living sacrifice. Paul ends Romans with how to live. "I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship" (12:1). We do not obey to be saved. We obey because we have been.

THREAD WATCH

THE LAMB Once a year, on the Day of Atonement, the high priest sprinkled blood on the mercy seat, the gold lid of the ark, and the next year he had to do it again. Paul's word for propitiation in Romans 3:25 is the same word the Greek Old Testament uses for that mercy seat. God put Jesus forward "as a propitiation by his blood," the sacrifice that turns away God's wrath once for all. The blood of the Lamb is how sinners are justified.

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE Paul wrote to an ordinary, troubled church in Corinth: "Do you not know that you are God's temple and that God's Spirit dwells in you?" (1 Cor. 3:16). The God who once filled a tent and a temple now lives among his gathered people.

The Turn: Right with God

The Philippian jailer asked the only question that finally matters: "What must I do to be saved?" Paul answered with a Person to trust: "Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved."

Most people assume that being right with God depends on being good enough, that God will weigh our good against our bad. Paul says that scale only condemns us. But God "justifies the ungodly" (Rom. 4:5). He takes guilty people, counts the perfect righteousness of Christ to them, and declares them right with him, as a gift, received by faith alone. Paul could write, "I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me. And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me" (Gal. 2:20).

"If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved" (Rom. 10:9). If you have never done that, do it today. And if you have, stop trying to earn what God has already given. Rest in it, and then go and live as a living sacrifice. Saul the persecutor became Paul the apostle by grace alone. That same grace is offered to you.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read Romans 1–8.** Read it in two or three sittings. Underline every "justified," "faith," and "grace."
2. **Say it plainly.** Write out in three sentences how a sinner is made right with God. Use Romans 3:23–26.
3. **Stop earning.** Notice when you feel you must perform to be accepted by God. Remind yourself of Romans 8:1.
4. **Pray for the hardest case.** Think of the person you consider least likely to become a Christian. Pray for them by name every day this week. God saved Saul.
5. **Present your body.** Choose one concrete way to offer your time, your body, or your money to God this week as a living sacrifice (Rom. 12:1).
6. **Memorize Romans 5:1.** "Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ."

Before Lesson 25: *Read Hebrews 1:1–4 and 4:14–16, James 2:14–26, 1 Peter 1:3–9, and 1 John 1:5–2:2. Lesson 25 looks at the letters of Peter, James, John, and Hebrews.*

For Discussion

1. Why do you think God chose a persecutor like Saul to be his great apostle? What does that tell you about grace?
2. Paul preached differently in the synagogue and in Athens, but the message was the same. What stayed the same?
3. Paul suffered beatings, shipwreck, and prison. How could he say his life was not precious to him?
4. In your own words, what does it mean to be justified? Why does it matter that it is a verdict and a gift?
5. Romans 3:23 says all have sinned. Why is that hard for many people to accept?
6. If we are saved by grace and not by works, why do good works still matter?
7. Which part of Romans 8 gives you the most hope? Why?

Sources & For Further Study

- On justification: Westminster Confession of Faith 11; Westminster Shorter Catechism 33; John Murray, *Redemption Accomplished and Applied*.
- On Paul and Romans: Douglas J. Moo, *The Epistle to the Romans*; John Stott, *The Message of Romans*; F. F. Bruce, *Paul: Apostle of the Heart Set Free*.
- For further reading: R. C. Sproul, *Faith Alone*; Timothy Keller, *Romans 1–7 For You*.



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